conflict, these laws have also given rise to new forms of conflict between the state and civil society.

Central to these reforms have been the rights to organize and freedom of speech, although these rights are not unqualified. Important reforms in the area of labour organizations and dispute settlement have allowed for greater protection of the workers' rights. According to the law, workers are now permitted to form unions and undertake collective bargaining (Kyaw Soe Lwin 2014).[24] A new law on freedom to demonstrate and protest was enacted, although it still required applications to the police for permission to protest, and provides the grounds on which a request could be denied, or criminal prosecutions made.[25] Like many reforms in this area, there are significant problems with implementation, as many applications for a permit to protest never receive a response from authorities, or are denied. Protestors who go ahead with their protests without a permit have been arrested and jailed. This situation prompted parliament to amend the law, which now simply requires consent to be given to all applications for a permit to protest (whereas before a request could be denied). In addition, the term of the maximum sentence that may be imposed for breach of the law has been reduced from two years to one, from one year to six months, and from six months to three months. Yet these amendments are minimal and concerns remain over the implementation of the law to silence criticism of the military, and contain political opposition and student activism. In fact, the violence legitimated by this law — in terms of arrests and imprisonment — demonstrates the way law can be used to effectively sanction and legalise harassment.

The removal of former restrictions on the media has significantly transformed the information space, and this sector is now regulated by a new media law.[26] The media, however, remains subject to certain limitations, for example, as mentioned above, the risk of being charged with contempt of court when reporting court cases perceived to be critical of the government. The new Association Registration Law has opened up greater freedom for civil society organizations. Registration is now voluntary, and no criminal sanctions are attached to non-registration.[27] This is a shift from earlier attitudes heavily circumscribing civil society organizations.

A number of laws on the legislative agenda significantly affect civil society and the freedoms and rights of individuals. One particularly heated debate has been over the National Education Law,[28] which was